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The widow of Zarephath

A poor foreign widow who shared her last meal and saw God keep her alive.

The widow of Zarephath lived in the country of Sidon, the homeland of Queen Jezebel and a centre of Baal worship. During the great drought of Ahab's reign she was down to her last handful of flour. She was gathering sticks for one final meal when Elijah, a stranger and an Israelite, asked her to feed him first. She did, and her flour and oil lasted until the rain came. Later, when her son died, Elijah prayed and the boy lived again. Scripture never tells us her name. Yet Jesus chose her story to show that God's mercy reaches beyond Israel, and his hometown was furious.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
Home	Zarephath, a town that "belongeth to Zidon" (1 Kings 17:9)
Family	A widow with one son (1 Kings 17:12)
When	During the drought in Ahab's reign, c. 860s BC
Key people	Elijah; her son
Main passages	1 Kings 17:8–24; Luke 4:25–26
New Testament	Mentioned by Jesus as a widow of "Sarepta" (Luke 4:26)

"And the woman said to Elijah, Now by this I know that thou art a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in thy mouth is truth."

1 Kings 17:24, KJV

The life of The widow of Zarephath

Dates are approximate. The drought falls in Ahab's reign (c. 874–853 BC), probably in the 860s BC. Kings gives no exact year.

During the drought	● God's command When the brook Cherith dries up, God sends Elijah to Zarephath. He says he has "commanded a widow woman there to sustain thee." She does not yet know it. <i>1 Kings 17:7-9</i>
At the city gate	● Meets Elijah She is gathering sticks when a stranger asks for water and a piece of bread. She has only a handful of flour and a little oil, and she expects to eat it with her son and then die. <i>1 Kings 17:10-12</i>
That day	● Bakes for the prophet first Elijah tells her not to fear. She should make him a small cake first, trusting God's promise that her flour and oil will last until the rain. She does as he says. <i>1 Kings 17:13-15</i>
Many days	● The jar does not run out Through the long drought the flour and oil keep lasting. They feed her, her household and Elijah, "according to the word of the LORD, which he spake by Elijah." <i>1 Kings 17:15-16</i>
Later	● Her son dies Her son falls sick until there is no breath left in him. In her grief she asks whether the prophet has come to call her sin to remembrance and slay her son. <i>1 Kings 17:17-18</i>
The same day	● Her son is raised Elijah carries the boy to his upstairs room, stretches himself on him three times, and cries to God. The child revives, and she confesses that Elijah is a man of God. <i>1 Kings 17:19-24</i>

Key activities

She was a Gentile living in Baal's own country. Yet she speaks of "the LORD thy God" (1 Kings 17:12) and acts on the word of his prophet.

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Helped a stranger. When Elijah asked for water, she went to fetch it, though water was scarce. *1 Kings 17:10-11*
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Told the truth about her need. She did not pretend. She had "not a cake, but an handful of meal in a barrel, and a little oil in a cruse." *1 Kings 17:12*
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- 3

Gave first. She made Elijah's cake before her own, trusting a promise she could not yet see. *1 Kings 17:13-15*
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- 4

Opened her home. Elijah stayed in an upstairs room of her house for many days. *1 Kings 17:15, 19*
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- 5

Brought her grief to the prophet. When her son died, she poured out her grief and fear honestly to Elijah. *1 Kings 17:17-18*
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Confessed her faith. Receiving her son alive, she declared that the word of the LORD in Elijah's mouth was truth. *1 Kings 17:23-24*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the widow.

Old Testament

1 Kings 17:8-24	The only account of her life
Obadiah 1:20	Zarephath as a boundary in a promise of return
Echo: 2 Kings 4:1-37	Elisha multiplies a widow's oil and raises a son
Echo: Deuteronomy 10:18	God defends the widow and loves the stranger

New Testament

Luke 4:25-26	"Unto none of them was Elias sent, save unto Sarepta"
Luke 4:28-29	Nazareth's synagogue, enraged, tries to throw Jesus off a cliff
Echo: Luke 7:11-17	Jesus raises a widow's only son at Nain
Echo: Mark 12:41-44	A poor widow gives "all her living"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What exactly did Elijah ask the widow to do, and what did he promise (1 Kings 17:13-14)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus used her story in his hometown sermon (Luke 4:25-29). Why would a foreign widow be such a pointed example?
3. *Apply:* She gave from almost nothing. What is one thing, however small, that you could give this week before you feel you have enough?
4. *Apply:* In her grief she blamed herself and the prophet (1 Kings 17:18). How do you tend to react when trouble comes even after you have obeyed God?